

FUTHARK

**A Handbook of
Rune Magic**

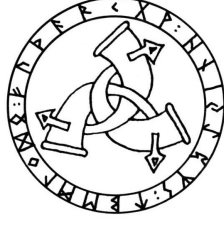


Edred Thorsson

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List of Abbreviations

All translations from Old Norse, Old English, and other old languages found in this book are those of the author. An attempt has been made to strike a balance between poetic and literal translation, but often favor is given to the literal for the sake of correct understanding. In such cases, notes may be added.

A-S	Anglo-Saxon (OE)
B.C.E.	Before Common Era
C.E.	Common Era
GMC	Germanic
GO	Gothic
MS	Manuscript
OE	Old English
ON	Old Norse
pl.	plural
sig.	singular

Transcriptions of Old Norse Terms

Certain special Germanic graphics have been transliterated in this book. The following are in keeping with certain spelling conventions of the Middle Ages:

ð	dh
þ	th
q	ö

INFO

Acknowledgments

I wish to acknowledge the help and inspiration given to me by my allsherjargodhi, Stephen A. McNallen. I also wish to thank my wife Nancy, without whom this work would have been impossible.

Preface

The present work is actually a second version of a manuscript originally written in the *Armanen*-system, which was completed in 1976 C.E. Soon thereafter, I discovered the deeper, long hidden power of the Elder Runic Tradition—which is transpersonal and fundamentally independent of the misinterpretations and manipulations of uninformed individuals. This misinformation has unfortunately been the hallmark of almost all books on operant runology which have appeared in recent years. In 1979 C.E., the revised manuscript of *Futhark* was complete. However, it has taken four years for it to find a publisher with the ability to bring it before a readership. During the intervening years, I have continued my investigations into the runes on all levels, and some of my ideas have evolved—based upon exoteric as well as esoteric work. Almost no changes have been made in the 1979 version, however, since it was, and is, fundamentally sound due to its foundation in the eternal *traditional* futhark-system. It is hoped that these more developed ideas will also be able to find a larger audience, and it is to that end that the Institute for Runic Studies, Asatru, and the Rune-Gild were founded in 1980 C.E. As it stands, *Futhark* remains the first step in learning the “ABC’s” of the esoteric wisdom of our Germanic heritage.

EDRED

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Introduction

Much has been hinted at concerning the runes and their magical power in recent books. However, none of these works has delved into the practical magical uses of the ancient Germanic runes and the system they embody, and in which they are in turn contained. It is the avowed intention of this work to rectify this dismal state of affairs, to deal with the practical side of the half-forgotten, much neglected runic system of magic and mysticism. This is still one of the most powerful forms of metaphysical thought available to the Westerner and one which he himself developed.

The roots of runic tradition have been hidden from our view for several hundred years, but now the long-awaited age has arrived, in which the power of the runic mysteries will again become manifest. Among English-speaking magicians rune knowledge had been steadily on the decline since the days of King Cnut, but their lore never completely died out—especially in Scandinavia, where runic incantations (*galdrar*) continued to be practiced until fairly recent times. This work is intended to invoke the runic force in the minds of all men and women, so that their lore and mysterious power may again be born to rise to the level of their former splendor in the English-speaking world. The runes embody the greatest and the smallest secrets of nature, and they are the keys to those secrets—for they are indeed the secrets themselves. Too long have these magnificent tools of magic been allowed to atrophy in dusty tomes. Now their ways are again made known to those who would be wise.

Rune lore represents an important part of the oldest tradition of initiatory wisdom-magic known to the Germanic world. The ancient Goths, Scandinavians, Germans, and English all knew the power of the runes, and they were bound together by a mighty guild of runemasters, who taught their craft throughout all the tribes of Northern Europe. It would seem wise for the descendants of these forebears to turn to the runic power to regain the depths of their

hoary wisdom. For if we are to believe their lore, these ancestors never died but rather were reborn, generation after generation, always keeping their secrets with them—until now, *they are us*. Through the runic keys we may again unlock these secret recesses of the soul and thus unleash wisdom and magical power for our own use today.

The runes and the runic system, as an eternal expression of world laws, may be constantly put to new uses without in any way violating their timeless and archaic characteristics. Therefore, they are now used in systems of psychological integration and cosmological investigation—both of which are actually firmly based on precepts found in the Eddas.

One of the most potent aspects of the runic system of magic and philosophy is its openness and lack of dogmatism. Information given in this book is intended to be a guide for the talented and inventive viti, who should use it as a stepping stone toward becoming a true philosopher in his *or* her own right. Again, the traditions of the Eddas and sagas are the best indicators of the spiritual directions the viti should take in order to get the best results. In ancient times every free man was his own priest—so it should be today. As far as a plan of development and initiation is concerned, it is suggested that the aspiring viti should read through the entire book, developing a personal version from the complete system given in the following pages. However, even today there exists a rune guild that provides a more systematic initiation for the dedicated viti. This book is divided into three main sections, containing the knowledge, theory, and practice of runecraft. This, coupled with other viable books on magic, forms the basis for a fairly advanced level of initiation. It is impossible to express the vastness of a system as all-encompassing as the Kabbalah or Vedic literature in a book of this or any other length. Putting even this basic system of mainly practical runic magic in one volume has been quite difficult. It is hoped that further interest in the runes will be kindled, so that future books dealing with divination, cosmology, wisdom-lore, and so forth, may be produced.

There have been several books and articles written in the last few years that connected the National Socialist movement in Germany with the runic cult and rune magic. Indeed, the Nazis made use of the runic forms in their most external and manipulative aspects. The beginning rune *viki* of today may take some strange comfort from the fact that the runes showed themselves to be such potent symbols in the twentieth century! But it must be strongly emphasized that the runes and indeed the Germanic spirit itself was *not* at the heart of this "bureaucratic blasphemy," but rather it was a

sort of pseudo-Christian messianic Manicheism that owned the soul of the Nazi Party. Much of the historical background of the runic aspects of the Nazi movement will be discussed in the first chapter of this book, for through an understanding of its perversions of our most sacred treasures we may truly put its unwelcome specter to rest once and for all!

An endeavor has been made throughout this book to remain as close as possible to the traditional *form* and *spirit* of lore and to present a system as free as possible from any Judeo-Christian influence. Too long has the Westerner suffered "bearing the cross of alien fruits." They have had their chance and have failed time and again in their impotent effort to satisfy the depths of the Indo-European soul. Their aeon has come to an end; the time is ripe for a reemergence of the wisdom of the *Erlói*! The breakthrough of holy power must take place within the soul of each individual—and it is in this hope that this work has been wrought.

~~Austin, 12:00~~ ~~Midhsumar~~

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Rune Knowledge

Definitions

The first step in understanding rune lore is the understanding of the concept *rune*. A rune is not merely a letter in an old Germanic alphabet, but rather it bears the primary definition of “secret” or “mysterium.” This basic meaning may be easily compared to the use of the term *arana* in connection with the Tarot. Therefore, a rune is primarily a secret, holy concept or idea that must be expressed or dealt with in concealment. Throughout this work, “rune” should be understood first in the sense of a secret and holy concept.

The word “rune” is indigenous to the Germanic group of languages, and it is found in all the ancient Germanic dialects. See Table 1.1 on page 2.

The modern German cognate is *raunen*, to whisper. *Rún* is also found in old Celtic languages, where it appears in Old Irish as *rín*, and in Middle Welsh as *rin*, both with the meaning of mysterium, secret. It is probable that the Celts borrowed the semantic quality of this word from the Germanic languages. “Rune” developed from the Proto-Indo-European root **ren-*, to roar.

Later this meaning was applied to each hieroglyphic figure that represented a rune—a unit of secret lore. It is this form that is inscribed as a symbol for a formless and timeless idea. Still later this

Table 1.1. Germanic Rune Definition

Dialect	Word	Meaning
Old Norse	rún	secret, secret lore, wisdom; magical signs; written characters.
Gothic	rúna	secret, mysterium. Wulfilas, in his fourth-century Gothic translation of the Bible, uses this term to translate the Greek <i>μυστήριον</i> .
Old English	rún	mystery, secret council.
Old Saxon	rúna	mystery, secret
Old High German	rúna	mystery, secret

symbol was incorporated into a system of writing that imparted a phonetic value to each symbol form. Now the rune has become mistakenly synonymous with the concept “letter,” as expressed in other languages.

Only a certain number of the various forms of the rune hoard were ever used as phonetic representations (which we will call letter runes), while a large number remained more or less within the purely ideographic realm. This latter group may be referred to as glyph runes. This work primarily deals with the letter runes and the magical system in which they developed, although the glyph runes are an integral part of this system as well. It must be kept in mind that both groups are equally runic. The letter runes were “standardized” in the futhark system by the magical guilds of the time, according to particular numerological and conceptual criteria.

Magical Definitions

According to most scholars, the runes were ancient symbols used in writing, mainly on stone or metal. These symbols bore religious or magical significance for the people who inscribed them—this cannot be denied by the most dreary of scholars.

For the rune viti, however, the signs take on a much richer and more expanded meaning that reveals their true nature and power as well as their historical and cosmic significance. The viti sees hieroglyphs of a highly complex nature in the forms of the runes. Investigation and research into intellectual and magical realms has revealed the runes as ideographs expressing a process and flow of force and energy.

Each rune has a threefold nature, which is also the threefold essence of the secret slumbering within it. The points are:

- Form (ideograph and phonetic value)
- Idea (symbolic content)
- Number (its dynamic nature, revealing its relationship to other runes).

They describe energy flows and states as related to the self, to the planet, and ultimately to the multiverse. The runes summarize and graphically express separate world concepts that can be used as focal points for magical and mystical operations, both singly and in combination.

Origin of the Runes

Here we speak more of the origin of the runic shapes than of the origins of the mysteries they represent. The actual mysteries are timeless and were created—or more properly, “came into being”—with the emergence of the Nine Worlds out of Ginnungagap. In fact the runes are important agents in this process of “creation” or “shaping,” and precede the arising of animate beings in the Worlds. The runic forms may be spoken of in a somewhat more historical context. These shapes are ultimately born from the holy signs conceived in the minds of the Bronze Age priests and magicians (and probably much earlier) as abstract graphic expressions of the innermost content of their religious and magical teachings (see Figure 1.1). They are found in great abundance on the most ancient rock carvings of Scandinavia. Rudolf John Gorsleben describes the “primal man” sitting atop a mountain receiving conceptual flashes of inspiration, which he then emotionally expresses in markings that come to be those concepts.

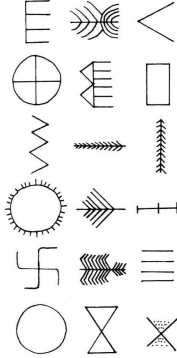


Figure 1.1. Some Bronze Age ideographic rock-carving configurations that were to evolve into runic shapes.

In the earliest period these so-called “pre-runic” signs remained totally ideographic or hieroglyphic. However, when contact was made with the Mediterranean cultures, the notion of phonetically representing language by symbols was slowly introduced into the Germanic territories. Many scholars believe that this introduction began in the second century B.C.E., when the Cimbric and Teutones invaded the Italian peninsula and came into contact with the North Etruscan and Latin alphabets; while others believe that the runes were ultimately formulated by the Goths in the first and second centuries C.E., while that tribe was still on the Baltic coast. These theories are all very interesting and hold many truths, but this is not our main interest. It is important to notice that when the Germanic peoples chose a rune (cultic sign) to represent a sound in their language, they would usually (but not always) choose a shape that in some way resembled the corresponding Etruscan, Latin, or Greek character. This undoubtedly plays a large role in the formulation of *galdrar* and their associations with certain runic forms.

The internal structure, ordering, naming, and symbolic content of these glyphs are totally unaffected by the Mediterranean cultures. There is a magical deep-structure that governs these factors. This deep-structure was well known by the priests and magicians of the Germanic cult, and they carefully formulated the runic ideology and transmitted it across tribal boundaries through preexisting cultic channels. Through this ancient guild of runemasters the runic system was able to maintain a high level of internal integrity despite crossing countless tribal lines over several centuries. As early as the first century C.E. Tacitus describes the runes being used in fully developed divinatory rites.

Mythically, it is through the “God of Magic,” Óðhinn, that the gods and men are able to receive rune wisdom. Óðhinn is the first being to be fully initiated into the rune mysteries; that is, he first extracted the rune wisdom directly from its source and formulated it within his being in such a way that it could be *communicated* to other beings. Therefore, it is through the Óðhinnic force that the runes may be perceived best. This initiatory myth is represented in the *Elder*, or *Poetic Edda*, in the song called “Hávamál”: “the sayings of Hár” (Hár: the High One = Óðhinn). Stanzas 138 and 139 of this song read:

I know, that I hung
on the windy tree
all of the nights nine,
wounded by spear
and given to Óðhinn;
myself to myself,

on that tree,
which no man knows,
from what roots it rises.
They dealt me no bread
nor drinking horn,
I looked down,
I took up the runes
I took them screaming,
I fell back from there.

This describes an initiatory process of a shamanistic type, in which the initiate passes through the Nine Worlds of the World-Tree to the realm of Hel (Death) and momentarily enters her sphere. At that moment the initiate receives the entire body of rune wisdom, and it is etched into his being. In the next instant, the initiate returns to Midgardhr with the rune wisdom permanently encoded and ready for use and communication.

History of the Runes

The runic system may well have been fully developed by as early as 200 B.C.E. It is certain that the magico-religious practices of the ancient Germanic priesthood were aided by the use of many runic and/or pre-runic signs, for we still have these etched into stone all over Scandinavia.

The ideographic stage of runic development is the cradle of rune magic. In this earliest period the ideographs would appear in isolation. Soon, however, magical sound and number formulas (*galdrar*) began to be produced, which were intended to have particular magical effects. Not long after this development the runes were being used to write in the common Germanic dialect. In all of these stages of development magical considerations were primary. All three types of runic formulations—ideographic, sound-formulaic, and phonetic word representations—continued to be used side by side, and thus all three modes are valid for our modern runic practices. Examples of these types will be provided and interpreted in the practical sections of the book. Runes have been found carved on wood, stone, metal, and bone objects. Unfortunately, the vast majority of the runic talismans were crafted in wood—which of course rotted rather quickly. It is most important to remember that the runes were born from a magical tradition, not a purely linguistic one, and that this magical association never left them.

As mentioned above, the runes began to be used to represent language phonetically soon after the Germanic peoples came into contact with the Mediterranean cultures in the second century B.C.E. Inscriptions remain the principal mode of crafting runes. The greatest number of runic inscriptions are on runestones, of which approximately twenty-five hundred are known (there is a total of almost five thousand runic artifacts in all). The runestones were raised as sacred landmarks and memorials all over Scandinavian countries. There are even controversial runestones in the United States. Runes have marked the path of Nordic trade routes from Eastern Europe to Greenland and from the Arctic Circle to Greece and Constantinople.

Writing and Art

Only a few scattered instances of runes occur in written manuscripts, and few of them seem to have any overt magical intent, although they may be reflections of magical practices. Rune poems found in Anglo-Saxon and Scandinavian traditions are of extreme importance, and portions of these will be discussed under certain runes. The oldest manuscript containing runic symbols is the *Abecedarium Nordmannicum* from the ninth century C.E. The *Codex Runicus* is a fourteenth-century Danish manuscript written entirely in runes; it contains the laws of the province of Sconia. In the Swedish period of the Thirty Years War (1630-1635), the Swedish forces of Gustavus Adolphus used the runes as a kind of code to confuse Austrian intelligence.

The glyph runes often are found incorporated into runic inscriptions. The most common of these is the *Thörs-hamarr* (the hammer of Thórr) or fylfot 卐 . This symbol represents the dynamic magical force of the Æsir and the explosive power of the Thunderer. The cross, or sunwheel $\oplus$, also is common from the Bronze Age onward. This ancient common European symbol was used to denote holy places and was later adopted by the Christians in their efforts to convert the folk who used it. More recently, of course, the Nazis revived the runes as manipulative tools and made the *Hakenkreuz* (hook-cross) their symbol, and the Schutzstaffel adopted a double S-rune, 卐 , as their identifying mark. These latter are to a large degree imbalanced misdirections of the runic forces.

As we look around today we still may see runic forms in proliferation. The "peace symbol," so prevalent in the sixties, is in the form of the Yr-rune of the Younger Futhark (an alternate form of the *elihaz* and *eliaz* of the elder row). Ambulances now carry a bright blue Hagall rune (in its later letter-rune form), which even includes a

caduceus symbol (see *Hagalaz*, p. 35). These and other examples give rise to the thought that there is surely something emotionally innate in these runic forms that rises to the surface repeatedly—no matter how much some attempt to suppress them with barren "reason."

The art of old Germanic architecture preserves the runes in the forms of the *Fachwerk* (half-timbered) building style, which has spread all over the world (see Figure 1.2). Originally, the timbers of the *Fachwerk* were placed in such a way as to form the shape of a rune. The magical significance of this is that the runic power would then be imparted to the building and its inhabitants. This custom continued on into the days when the builders no longer knew why the timbers were laid in these particular ways—it became simple tradition. The now familiar "Dutch hex signs" also are ultimately derived from a runic source.

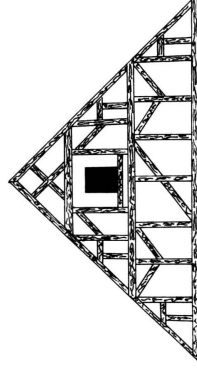


Figure 1.2. Examples of runic patterns found in German half-timbered buildings.

In the plastic arts we find the famous example of the golden ritual drinking horns of Gallehus. On these horns there are human figures in particular stances and postures that are certainly representations of cultic signs and runes. The style of these figures is employed in this book to represent the various *rinastildir* (sometimes called "runic asanas"). Another, more obscure example of this practice is the so-called Herrgott von Bentheim (Lord God of Bentheim). This curious piece of statuary is based on a wooden original that was brought into the town of Bentheim from a nearby Thingstead. The arms of the figure are bent in the shape of the Anglo-Frisian rune v (see the T-rune for an explanation of the symbol complex involved here). The stone reconstruction was then given a Christian significance; however, even today it is used as an object on which solemn oaths are sworn.

Historically, there have been three ancient codifications of the letter runes: the Elder Futhark (24 runes), the Anglo-Saxon or

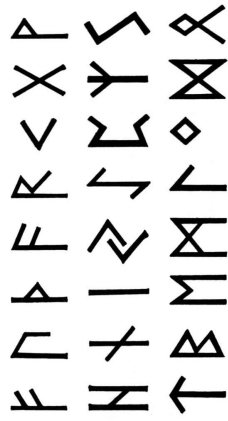


Figure 1.3. The Elder Futhark.

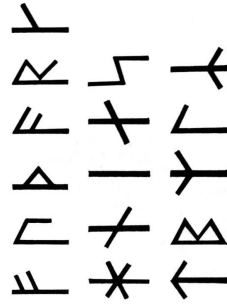


Figure 1.4. The Younger Futhark.

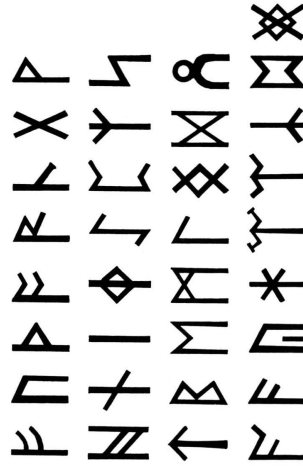


Figure 1.5. The Anglo-Saxon Futhorc.

Frisian row (33 runes), and the Norse (or Younger) Futhark (16 runes). (See Figures 1.3, 1.4, and 1.5 on page 8.) The latter two are modifications of the first one. That these modifications took place within a traditionally controlled cult of some type is well indicated by the methodical manner in which the order and correspondences of the runes were maintained. Information on some of these correspondences may be found in the Table of Correspondences, printed as Appendix D. This book deals more or less exclusively with the system of the Elder Futhark, which was the rule between ca. 200 B.C.E. and 800 C.E. However, *the other two systems are also magically valid*. The Younger Futhark began to be developed in the seventh century C.E., and this development was complete by about 800 C.E., while the Anglo-Saxon Futhorc was able to survive the Christianization process until the tenth century C.E. Among all the various systems, the shapes of individual runes and in many cases their names often would be altered. This sometimes offers us valuable clues and correspondences to their inner nature. Much of this lore will be revealed in the sections on the individual runes. It is hoped that talented vitkar will be inspired by these other systems and develop them further for modern magical practice.

House Marks and Heraldry

In the Middle Ages and after, in the continental Germanic territory, the runes were driven underground, where they found further expression through various graphic arts attributed to the early nobility and farmers. House marks are symbolic or literal monograms, formed from two or more runes often stylistically modified. These house marks were used as identification for property, and in the Middle Ages they were inscribed into objects owned by lord and freeman. In contrast to crests and coats-of-arms, the house mark could be drawn without color and by an unpracticed hand. Although the tradition and form of the house mark grew out of the more elaborate heraldic art, it developed separately from it but was later reincorporated beside the crest. The house mark also could be used as a signature after the fashion of a monogram.

According to Guido von List, the history of house marks is a three-stage development. In the first period, which lasted through the middle of the fifteenth century, the marks still were formed and interpreted according to ancient runes and holy signs, and their value was highly symbolic and cultic. An example of this is shown in Figure 1.6 on page 10.

The second historical period spans the time from the middle of the fifteenth century to the middle of the eighteenth century. In this

era the runic forms of the letters making up the last name, or initials of the first and last names, were welded together into one form (see Figure 1.7). Here it can be seen that runes have lost their deeper symbolic value in this period. They have been transformed from purely cultic forms to phonetic symbols used to write the name.

After the second historical period (fifteenth to eighteenth century) the use of runes was dropped. Latin script was used, usually to form the initials of a person's name, as shown in Figure 1.8.



Figure 1.6. Ideographic German house mark. The symbolic interpretation of this mark has the two thorns of life þ and death ǀ with the Hammer of Thor between them. The esoteric reading is "Between life and death may my estate increase and prosper."



Figure 1.7. Runic German house mark. The name FRYDEL is portrayed in this composite form.



Figure 1.8. Monographic German house mark: Latin script forming the initials of a person's name.

Stonemasons' signs, merchants' signs, and masters' signs may in some cases be interpreted according to the same rules that govern the formation and reading of house marks. The three-stage history of house marks is most revealing as to the degeneration of the use of runes into modern times, but by retracing the path the rune *vitki* may regain some of what otherwise would have been lost.

Heraldic art is an extremely vast topic, and it is beyond the scope of this book to deal with its runic implications. Let it simply and tentatively be said that the runes *may* be found in heraldic art in two ways: (1) they may be embodied in the color pattern that composes the coat-of-arms; or (2) the concept of the rune may be concealed by a symbolic form or figure other than the shape of the runic symbol itself.

A Note on the Tarot and Runes

Some German investigators of this century have guessed that the runes actually are the origin of the Tarot system of the Major Arcana. This may or may not be true—or there may have been some point at which the two systems came into contact. In any event the runes, of course, have a documented past that goes back much farther than documentation for the Tarot. Appendix D provides some conjectural Tarot correspondences, and the commentaries on the individual runes occasionally give some interesting parallels. But it is up to each interested *vitki* to come to his or her own conclusions on this matter.

Runic Practices

As mentioned above, the runes are found carved on wood, stone, metal, and bone objects. Wood is most certainly the favorite medium for portraying runes—especially for magical purposes. Words for "pieces of wood" associated with the runes are numerous. Three Old Norse examples of this connection would be the words *sláfr* (stave, letter, secret lore), *leinn* (twig, talismanic word for divination), and *hlutr* (lot for divination, talismanic object—on which runes also were carved). There are also a few stone talismans, but of course the large runestones for cultic or funeral-ceremony purposes represent the most numerous runic inscriptions in stone. Metal was extremely popular for talismanic purposes. The bracteates (thin metal disks inscribed with runes and various other designs) represent an important tradition in magical runic practice. Other, more utilitarian objects made of metal (especially swords) also were inscribed with runes in order to impart special magical powers to them so that they might perform their function with more distinction—or protect the user. Bone objects also are not uncommon, and these usually are connected with magical practices as well. The runes were carved with either knife points or special pointed instruments dedicated to the runic art.

One of the most interesting runic practices is that of further concealing the magical formula with intricately devised codes. These codes were created in order to make the messages more secret—and therefore more effective magically—and also less likely to be understood by the uninitiated. The basis of all the runic codes is the numerical value of the runes. The section of this book dealing with talismanic magic will delve into these traditions on a practical basis.

Both the Younger and Elder futharks are divided into three groups called *ættir* (families). The futharks represented in Figures 1.3-5 are divided in just this way. Through this system a rune may be represented by a twofold numerical formula. For example, : h : would be indicated by the formula 1:2, because it is the first *ætt* and the second rune from the left. This is the basic principle upon which magical runic codes work. It should be noted that in the case of the Younger Futhark a curious and uniform alteration in the order of the *ættir* took place for purposes of magical codes (see Figure 1.9).

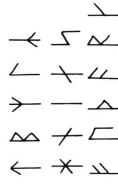


Figure 1.9. Coded runic order, altered from the "normal" order of the Younger Futhark (Figure 1.4).

These cryptic runic systems were most highly developed in the Younger Futhark period; however, they most certainly were known and used in the older period, since ancient representations of the elder row are also clearly divided into *ættir*. Two of the most remarkable methods of making secret runic codes are known by the names branch runes (ON *knústrúnar*) and tent runes (ON *hjaldrúnar*). An example of the tent-rune method is shown in Figure 1.10.

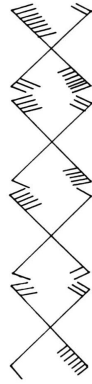


Figure 1.10. Tent-rune method, used here to spell the name *thorvaldr*.

These *hjaldrúnar* should be read in a clockwise direction, beginning on the left. Hence, a numerical formula of 1:3, 3:7, 1:5, 1:2, 1:4, 3:5, 3:8, 2:7 appears. (First *ætt* third rune reads þ, "th," etc.) The *knústrúnar* work in a similar way, except one may portray a single rune with a single glyph in this system. An example representing the magical formula *ek víki* (I, the Magician) appears in Figure 1.11. The strokes to the left of the vertical indicate the row, and those to the

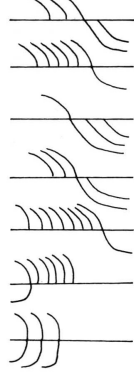


Figure 1.11. Branch runes representing the magical formula *ek víki* (I the Magician).

right reveal the runic position. Note that a change of word in the formula is indicated by the upward or downward direction of the *ætt* stroke! The ninth-century St. Gall MS 270 portrays several more cryptographic systems of rune writing.

Runes may be magically used in a wide variety of ways. The most common method of rune magic in days of yore was probably talismanic—that is, runes were inscribed into various objects and infused with psychic power in order to effect some change in the *vitki* or his environment. A dramatic example of this is provided by the *Egilssaga*, chapter 44, where we read that the hero, Egill, suspects that there is poison in a drink that has been given to him, so he stabs the palm of his hand, carves runes on the drinking horn, and colors the runic forms with the blood. The horn shatters and the poison flows away. Hundreds of runic talismans have survived. Today we may study these in order to gain a deeper understanding of the magical techniques used to create them. The use of poetic *runagaldrar* (runic incantations) also was quite common as a method. The *Poetic Edda*, as well as numerous runic artifacts, speak with the voice of many of these ancient runic incantations. The practice of *snadhagaldr* (posture magic or incantation) is evidenced by the drinking horns of Gallehus, which portray a variety of magical formulas, some of them in the shapes of humanoid figures in runic postures. Later Icelandic customs confirm this usage: for example, the teaching of the alphabet to young children by having them strike a posture that resembles a letter. All of these practices will be dealt with in detail in the practical portion of this book.

Another important use of the runes, which falls outside the scope of the present work, is that of divination. The runic forms often were carved into pieces of wood, cast onto a white cloth, and then interpreted according to strict criteria. The Roman historian Tacitus reports on this practice among the continental Germans in the first century C.E.

All of the methods mentioned above are valid and extremely potent for magical purposes today. The runes and holy signs may be

used as focal points for evocatory magic and meditation as well as self-transmutation and mystical communication. Runes are especially valuable in magical works concerning victory, success, protection, rescue from restriction, love, and the gaining of wisdom.

The Runic Revival

Although many runic practices, and much rune lore, continued in a myriad of forms long after the coming of Christianity, the systematic transmission of the sacred rune lore belonging to the ancient *vitkar* and *erlloz* slowly disappeared. By the nineteenth century only scattered pockets of "rune singers" remained in the remotest areas of Scandinavia. However, the runic mysteries are truly something indigenous to the innermost *selvis* of many members of the Germanic tribes, and this "inner rune lore" could never be eliminated totally—it only retreated into the innermost shelters of the human soul, waiting to be reborn. Just as the gods and men retreat into abodes in the recesses of Yggdrasill in order to survive the destructive powers released at Ragnarök, so too did the runes hide themselves in the patterns of consciousness, awaiting the time when they might be reborn into a hospitable world that would again know their lore. As we read in the Eddic "Völuspá" (stanza 59) concerning the renewed world after Ragnarök:

Again the AEsir meet
on Idha-plain,
and speak of the mighty
Midgardh-serpent,
and again remember
the mighty World-doom
and Fimbulýr's (=Óðinn's)
elder runes.

The rebirth process of the runes has not been without pain and blood. Until now, it seems the vessels were as yet unfit to receive the wholeness of runic power because these vessels still contained wine made from foreign fruit. Leaders of the first half of the runic renaissance still contained many of the notions and prejudices of the Christian world in which they found themselves, and in most cases they were unable to give up these notions. Therefore, they often incorporated these ideas into their runic systems. Sometimes this was done in an honest effort, but in some cases it was done in the spirit of malicious manipulation of the sacred symbols.

At the dawn of the twentieth century the Pan-Germanic mystic Guido von List received a spontaneous runic initiation in which the "secrets of the runes" were revealed to him while he lay in darkness, his eyes bandaged for several months because of a cataract operation. From that time in 1902 to his death in 1919, List worked toward the restoration of what he called "*Armanium*." He formed the Guido-von-List-Gesellschaft (Guido von List Society) to support his investigations, and the *Armanen Orden* to carry out the esoteric functions of that society. List's aims often were political in nature (such as the unification of his native Austria and Germany), and his theories were to some degree based on the anti-Semitic dogma of the day. However, it is his runic theories that interest us here. List developed a magical runic system of eighteen runes (which we will call the *Armanen* system). This was based solely on the textual authority of the "Rune-Song" in the Eddic lay "*Hávamál*."

Although List never wrote about the magical runic practices employed by the *Armanen Orden*, the first book he produced after his "runic initiation" was entitled *Das Geheimnis der Runen* [*The Secret of the Runes*], which outlined his interpretation of the eighteen runes portrayed in this Eddic poem, as well as his thoughts on a wide range of pertinent esoteric topics. This was the first in a series of works published between 1904 and his death in 1919. List maintained that the eighteen-rune system was the "primal" one, although there is no hard evidence other than the "*Hávamál*" to support his claim. The personal force of List and that of his extensive and influential *Armanen Orden* was able to shape the runic theories of German magicians (although not necessarily their political ones) from that time to the present day.

List's runic teachings later were incorporated into the racist *Germanen Orden*, which was one of the esoteric precursors of the National Socialist movement in Germany. His ideas also were further developed, and to some degree published, by two magicians, Siegfried Adolf Kummer and Friedrich Bernhard Marby, who developed a system of "runic yoga" and gymnastics that is worthy of study. Kummer and Marby are extremely important, since it is with their publications and experiments that the foundations of a practical and traditional system may be laid. But their ideas generally followed those of List and were not very traditional as far as the runes were concerned. They retained the *Armanen* system and further reinforced his racist ideas, as did another student, Rudolf John Gorsleben. Gorsleben's epochal work *Die Hoch-Zeit der Menschheit* (*The Zenith of Humanity*) is a huge compilation of rune lore based on the *Armanen* system. The early thirties seem to be the twilight of the first esoteric runic movement.

The year 1933 marks the beginning of the Nazi period, and by 1935 the *Älmenrebe* (institute for ancestral heritage) was formed by Heinrich Himmler around the ideas of Professor Hermann Wirth, among others. The runes formed an important part of Wirth's thinking, but we do not have many examples of practical applications of his ideas. During the Nazi regime all things "Germanic" were mobilized and perverted toward manipulative ends. The rune forces themselves were used much less than some might have us believe. The *Älmenrebe* and the *Totenkopf Orden* made more practical use of Judeo-Christian and Manichean techniques and ideas in their magical traditions and organizational principles. The ideology of the ex-Cistercian monk Jörg Lanz von Liebenfels, embodied in his *Orden des Neuen Tempels* (ONT), was most influential in this regard. One brief glance at a book on ancient Germanic and old Scandinavian culture and religion will show the massive degree to which the Nazis perverted the egalitarian systems of the ancients into a totalitarian scheme. This was done basically through the "Christian camouflage technique"; that is, just as the Christian evangelists would employ old pagan symbols (such as the cross) to convert the heathens and then gradually infuse those venerable symbols with a contrary significance, so too did the Nazis employ old Germanic symbolism (which was very popular at that time) and infuse it with non-Germanic concepts for manipulative purposes. Runes and holy signs were abundant in the symbolism employed by the Nazi party, but it is not within the scope of this work to delve into this aspect of runic history.

The practical use of the runes as a system of magic (other than state controlled) and personal development virtually died out or was driven underground during the Nazi period. After the war the *Älmenrebe* system was revived, and "reformed" by the German magician Karl Spiesberger. Spiesberger is a widely qualified, "eclectic" occultist who has authored books in the Hermetic as well as the runic tradition. His two principal works on runic topics are *Runenmagie* (*Runic Magic*) and *Runenexerziten für Jedermann* (*Runic Exercises for Everyone*). In these books Spiesberger synthesizes the work of all the German runic magicians and experts who preceded him, within a pansophical framework. Although he eliminates all the racist and *willich* elements, he retains the *Älmenrebe* system of runes, which by 1955 had become almost "traditional" in German circles! This system of eighteen runes forms a valid and working magical system, and the present work in traditional runic system(s) owes much to Spiesberger's research and synthesizing.

As valuable as Spiesberger's work is, it is still not a traditional form. Therefore, to some extent it is cut off from the innate powers

slumbering in the ancient runes and their system. Whereas the *Älmenrebe* system has a tradition dating only from around 1904 C.E., the oldest runic evidence dates from about two thousand years earlier. Documents of the Viking and pre-Viking ages give us ample clues as to how the runes were used, but Spiesberger is forced to neglect much of this material because it is the product of a different organic system. We know the elder traditions worked, and worked for hundreds of years, within well-developed cults. Therefore, it is certainly most fruitful to unlock the ancient runic treasure mounds that have stored the hoard of rune wisdom over the past millennia. But to do this, the psychic keys provided by the pioneering technical work done by the modern magicians in the *Älmenrebe* traditions is extremely helpful.

Traditional Rune Lore and Ásatrú

The traditional runic systems are based on any of the three ancient futharks shown in Figures 1.3, 1.4, and 1.5. The magical system and cosmology presented here are found in the Elder Futhark of twenty-four signs. The rebirth of this lore is founded on a synthesis of the humane sciences of comparative religion, anthropology, archeology, and linguistics (known collectively as linguistic paleontology) and the methods of magic. This holistic¹ view also incorporates the natural sciences. Thus, the methods of traditional rune lore are founded in what is known of a magical system that was developed in days of yore. The hoary *eriloz* still speak to us through their runestones and through the mind runes (ON *hugrúnar*) they represent in our consciousnesses. This magical system was, however, only part of a much larger cosmological pattern that encompassed all the known and unknown worlds. For the ancient Teutonic tribes magic, religion, and law—including social organization—were expressions of the same basic divine force. Therefore, in order for traditional magical forms to be truly reborn in Midgardhr, a vessel for this holistic conception first had to be nurtured.

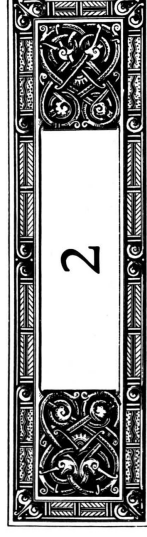
With the dawn of the eighth decade of this century, a northern wind blew through the world, allowing the venerable forms of magic, religion, and law to develop again in a syncretic reality. On May 16, 1973, the *Ásatrúarmenn* (those believing in, or trusting in the Æsir)

¹The use of the term "holistic" deserves some comment here. It is interesting to note that the Germanic idea of "holy" is identical to that embodied in "holistic"; i.e., the wholeness, completeness, and unity of all realms, leading to well-being. The English words "holy," "hale," and "whole" all derive from the same root: **kaila-* (whole, uninjured, of good omen).

was founded in Iceland by Sveinbjörn Beinteinsson. Although there had been precursors to this event earlier in the decade, it represented the crystalizing nexus of the movement that has come to be known as either Ásatrú (the faith of the Æsir) or Odinism. At present three major groups seem to foster this syncretic view: the Ásatrúarmenn in Iceland, the Ásatrú Free Assembly in California, and the Odinic Rite in England.

All of these groups maintain a healthy independence from one another—an independence that is matched by their mutual respect for and cooperation with one another. These organizations are primarily “religious” in orientation; all the tenets of this noble faith are too complex to enter into in this work. Besides, their general lack of dogmatism defies a quick synopsis, and any attempt at such would only do disservice to the remarkable breadth of religious expression and experience found within the perimeters of Ásatrú. However, let it be said that the efficiency of the magical system presented here can only be increased by an understanding of and adherence to the holistic principles of this faith, since this is the kind of atmosphere in which the rune lore was first practiced.

There exists a kind of “runic order” called the *Rúnagildi* (rune gild) that is made up of members from the Ásatrú Free Assembly and the Odinic Rite in England. This guild is dedicated to the teaching of runecraft and to a program of initiatory magical development within Ásatrú and according to traditional rune lore.



Lore of the Elder Futhark

In this chapter, which consists of twenty-four sections, each section is a systematic attempt to impart a body of lore that surrounds each of the runes of the Elder Futhark. Information contained in these sections may be applied directly to magical practice, and the intellectual understanding arising from this lore will serve to increase the depth of ritual experience. Further amplifications of this rune lore may be obtained from the tables of correspondences printed as Appendix D.

Each section is headed by the standard runic form exemplified by the majority of runic inscriptions in the elder row along with its numerical value. The rune names in Proto-Germanic (a reconstructed common ancestor of all Germanic languages), Gothic, Old English, and Old Norse are provided, together with their Modern English translations. Alternate forms of the rune found in various inscriptions also are given, followed by the phonetic value of the rune. This preliminary table concludes with an esoteric interpretation of the name(s) and an ideographic interpretation of the runic form. The body of the runic commentary provides mythological and cosmological as well as magical material pertinent to the understanding of the mystery embodied by the rune in question. These commentaries are intended to be only partial, while touching on the

major aspects of the mystery. They should serve as material for meditation and stimulus toward further work by all vitkar. A synopsis of the interpretation is given as a group of key words that serve as convenient vessels for containing the larger body of knowledge.

The last three divisions of each section consist of more technical material. The *galdr* is the root form of incantation (or if you will, *mantra*), which is the vibratory embodiment of the rune. This formula is invaluable to the rune vitki as a tool in all phases of rune magic, and together with the form, it is the principal medium through which the runic force finds expression. These formulas are very flexible and should be the subject of extensive experimentation by each vitki. Because of limitation of space, the complex poetic *galdrar* of the Nordic tradition may not be entered into here. The simple sound formulas are the most basic and therefore perhaps most useful in self-designed ritual work. The *stíðlur* (eg. *stáðlur*) presented in these sections are based on the methods of S.A. Kummer and F.B. Marby. They are quite effective and provide a powerful mode of literally incorporating the runic power into the body of the vitki, thus facilitating the assimilation or projection of these holy forces. The final division concerns the various uses of each individual rune for magical or mystical purposes. The lore of individual runes is the foundation of runecraft, from which their complex interactions spring. But it must be stressed that this lore is "open-ended." For talented and dedicated vitkar, there is no limit to the correspondences that can be integrated once the basics have been mastered and an understanding of the relative power contexts of each rune within the futhark paradigm has been reached.

COMMENTARY

Fehu is the raw archetypal energy of motion and expansion in the multiverse. It is the force that flows from Muspellshheimr, the source of cosmic fire, from which Midgardhr was produced (see I-rune). The F-rune is the all encompassing and omnipresent power symbolized by the charging bovine herd and by wildfire. The cosmic fire of Muspellshheimr is instrumental in the creation of the world, but it is also the principal agent in its destruction of Ragnarök. The fire-giant, Surtr, spreads the flames of destruction over the world, thus destroying all but those gods and men who are to survive or to be reborn in the renewed world on the Idha plain (the shining plain). It must be remembered that *fehu* is not the undifferentiated power of the cosmic fire of Muspellshheimr but rather the mystery of its eternal working eminently throughout the multiverse.

This rune rules the basic force of fertility. The F-rune contains the mystery of both creation and destruction and the harmonious functioning of these two extremes, which leads to dynamic evolutionary force. *Fehu* is the rune of eternal becoming. Along with several other runes, this describes the holy process of birth-life-death-rebirth, or arising-being/becoming-passing-away toward new arising. More specifically, *fehu* is the archetypal force that gives impetus to this eternal process.

The F-rune is the essence of mobile power. This is evident from the most mundane meaning of its name: "money" or "cattle" (contrast O-rune). This root word originally meant mobile wealth or property, then was attached to the concept of livestock, which was the main mobile form of property known to the most ancient Germanic peoples. Later this term was used for "money," hence the modern English word "fee."

All in all, the F-rune defines a mobile form of power. In the psycho-magical realm this concept of mobile force is closely connected with the old Germanic idea of the *hamingja*. This is an aspect of the psychosomatic complex that may be best described as a mobile and transferable magical power. The *hamingja* (which is often translated by such concepts as "luck," and even "guardian spirit") may be sent forth from an individual in a manner akin to that of the "astral body" in other traditions. *Fehu* is the directed expansive force that facilitates the projection of soul entities and magical power from person to person, or from a person to an object.

Often the power of the F-rune is manifested in the mythology as an otherworldly glow around grave mounds and hills, or even as a ring of fire.



1

Names: GMC *fehu*: mobile property, cattle
GO *fehu*: cattle, mobile property

OE *feoh*: cattle, money
ON *fé*: livestock, money

Alternate forms: $\mathbb{F}$ $\mathbb{F}'$ $\mathbb{F}''$

Phonetic value: f

Esoteric interpretation of name: mobile property; power.

Ideographic interpretation: the horns of bovine livestock.

Key words:

Mobile force

Energy, fertility

Creation/destruction
(Becoming)

Gald:

fehu fehu fehu

ffffff

fu fa fi fe fo

of ef if af uf

ffffff

Stadha:

Both arms slanted upward, the left being somewhat higher; fingers pointed for directing power, palms pointed out for drawing force. Face toward the sun.



Magical workings:

1. Strengthens psychic powers.
2. Channel for power transference or projection; the sending rune.
3. Drawing the projected power of the sun, moon, and stars into the personal sphere.
4. Promotion of personal and social evolution.
5. Increase in personal monetary wealth.

2

Names: GMC *uruz*: the aurochs

GO *úris*: the aurochs

OE *úr*: ox, bison

ON *úr*: drizzle, rain

Alternate forms: $\wedge \ \backslash \ \cap \ \cup \ \text{h} \ \text{h} \ \text{h}$

Phonetic values: *u*, *v*

Esoteric interpretation of names: aurochs—the primal forming force; Audhumla in the Edda, or drizzle—the primal fertilizing essence.

Ideographic interpretation: the horns of the aurochs, or falling drizzle.



COMMENTARY

The U-rune is the mother of manifestation. In the mythology this is represented by the great cow Audhumla, which licked a great icy block of salt in order to form the primal androgyne Búri. Also, she was the source of sustenance for the cosmic giant Ymir. Audhumla was herself formed from the dripping rime produced when the world fire met the world ice. This is also the unmanifested energized essence from which the cosmic ice and Audhumla were originally formed.

Uruz is the patterning and formulating power in the multiverse, the source of the ordering principles that lead to the final formulation of the world. The U-rune is the unmanifested pattern of matter (contrast with the antimatter nature of *isa*).

This is the cosmic seed, the world force analogous to the *semen virile*.

It contains the mystery of the formulation of the self, a composite paradigm of all the aspects of the psychosomatic complex, just as the multiverse is framed from the various worlds. *Uruz* is the forming force, not the form itself (see the H-rune).

The U-rune is the shaping power that defines the origin and destiny of all things. This mystery may be demonstrated through the shape of the stave, as shown in Figure 2.1. *Uruz* is the eternal reservoir of archetypal patterning.

Because of its shaping power, *uruz* is a rune symbolizing wisdom and lore, as the pattern of preserved tradition that is sprung from the natural order. Just as this indicates a healthy society (one in accordance with natural order), so too is this a rune of good physical health in the personal realm. The U-rune promotes strong and harmonious organic systems. It is the rune of vital strength and virility.



Figure 2.1. U-rune pattern of manifestation. This pattern is essentially that of being drawn up into the time-space continuum until the force of the I-rune eventually draws it back to its source.